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Mental Health Advocate

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GARRICK**

PAGE 2

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PAGE 7

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PAGE 12

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VICTORIA GARRICK

CURRENT MENTAL HEALTH & BODY IMAGE ADVOCATE GIVES ADVICE TO ATHLETES

July 6, 2020
Stephanie O'Brien

LRT SPORTS: WHAT WAS ONE OF THE HARDEST OR MOST FRUSTRATING MOMENTS IN YOUR RECRUITING PROCESS BEFORE YOU LANDED AT USC?

I think the most difficult part of the recruiting process is probably having to invest a lot of time into reaching out and talking to coaches and grabbing their attention. Most of the time I wouldn't get a response back, because college coaches are so busy and there's so much going on. The most difficult thing for me was always being unsure of where I stood, what [a coach's] interest level was, and just being able to read the recruiter's side

LRT SPORTS: WHAT ADVICE WOULD YOU GIVE TO AN ATHLETE WHO IS STRUGGLING WITH MENTAL HEALTH BUT FEELS LIKE THEY SHOULD JUST PLAY

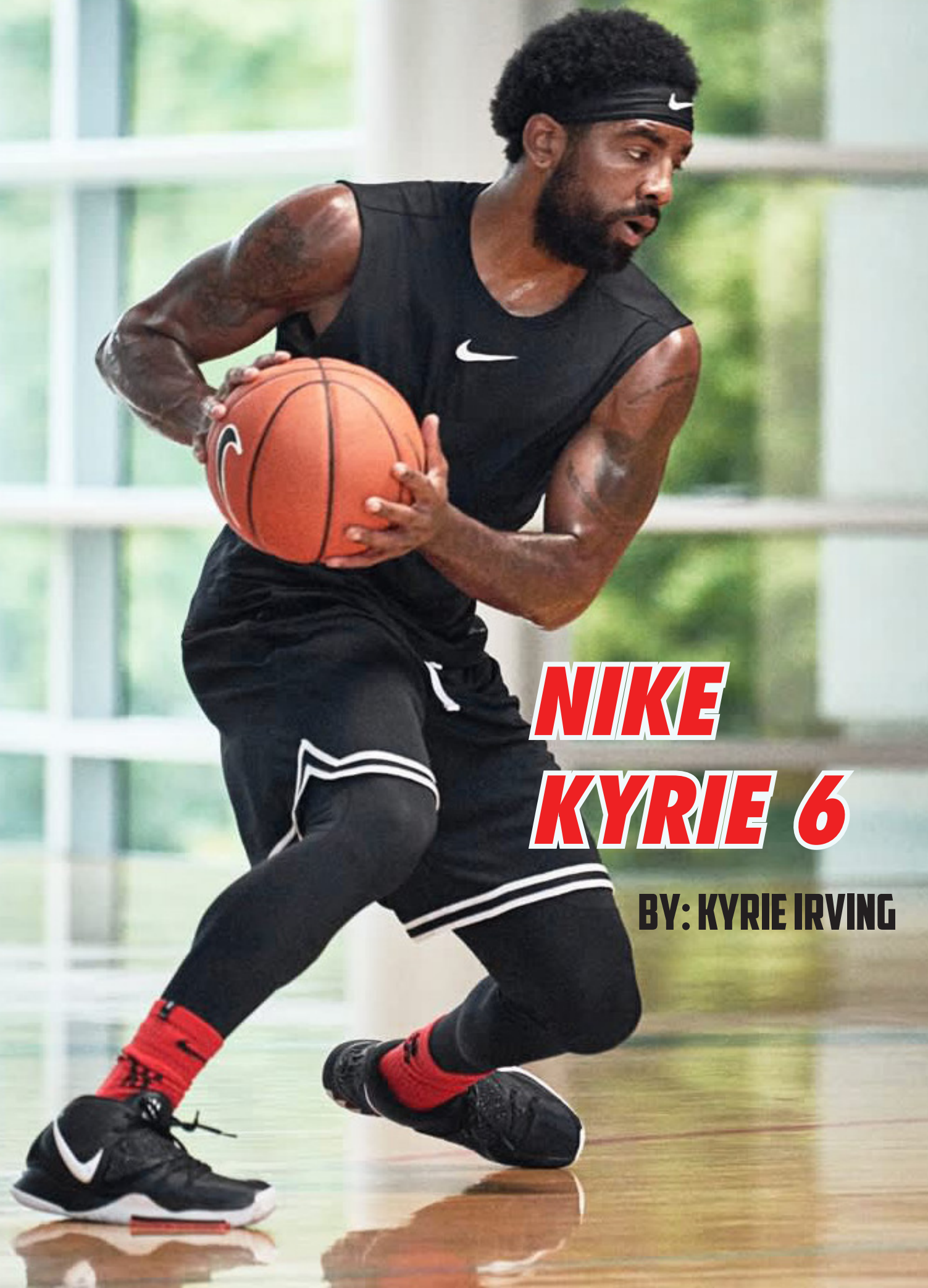
I would ask them—would you play through a sprained ankle? Would you play through an ACL tear? And their answer would hopefully be no. We are only going to make the injury worse if we ignore it and play on something that's hurting. It can be tough for athletes to understand that a mental health issue or a mental illness is an injury.

It's just invisible, but that doesn't mean it's any less severe, and that doesn't mean you should play on it just because people don't know about it. I would tell them it needs to be treated just like a physical injury and it's only going to get worse if we ignore it. Part of being a great player is identifying a weakness, identifying what needs work, and spending time there. The same way I would say my jump shots off, or I'm really bad at kicks from half field



604

digs placing her in the
top 5 of program history



NIKE KYRIE 6

Creativity Channeled With the Nike Kyrie 6 **AARON DODSON**
November 4, 2019

NEW YORK — Ben Nethongkome still remembers all the road trips he took to see Kyrie Irving two summers ago. The senior Nike footwear designer would hop in his car and make the nearly 200-mile drive from Portland, Oregon, to Seattle, where Irving spent three weeks of the 2018 offseason to reset ahead of his eighth year in the NBA, and the second one with the Boston Celtics, following two knee surgeries.

Nethongkome would watch him practice with fellow players in private workouts and pickup games led by league veteran Jamal Crawford. And when Irving wasn't training, they'd meet up to work on the Nike Kyrie 6, the latest installment of the point guard's line of signature sneakers.

“We sat down and invested hours in designing the shoe together,” Nethongkome recently recalled at the Brooklyn Nets HSS Training Center. “Really just busting out pen and paper and pencils and tapes and product. That was really refreshing to see an athlete get down and dirty with you. ... Kyrie’s a creative, on the court and even in design sessions. He’s not a guy who’s gonna sit in the back of the room and

More than a year after those meetings, the Kyrie 6 has finally arrived, marking a new chapter in the 27-year-old’s life and career. Irving — who signed a four-year, \$141 million deal in July with the Nets, a franchise he grew up supporting as a kid from West Orange, New Jersey — will debut the shoe on Monday night at Barclays Center in Brooklyn during a game against the New Orleans Pelicans.

For Irving, his new sneaker represents an authentic transition from athlete to artist. The six-time All-Star and NBA champion always envisioned designing his own shoe. And this time around, throughout the creation process of the Kyrie 6, he became more hands-on than he’d ever been with any of his previous five models.

“What separates my Kyrie 6 from the rest of my line is really just the creative design behind it,” Irving said. “I’ve had a huge, huge hand in a lot of designing processes before. But this is the one where I really, really started from being in a hotel room, having a bunch of ideas and boards, and trying to combine a bunch of my favorite shoes and favorite ideas into one.”

Irving is one of just six basketball players in the history of Nike Basketball — joining an elite company of Charles Barkley, Sheryl Swoopes, LeBron James, Kobe Bryant and Kevin Durant — to receive six or more signature sneakers during his/her playing career. (Penny Hardaway and Scottie Pippen each reached the mark after retiring. And though the Jordan Brand was officially established as a subdivision of Nike until 1997, Michael Jordan has always been in a category of his own with the company.)

Five years ago, at the age of 22 during his fourth season with the Cleveland Cavaliers, Irving got his first signature shoe — the Nike Kyrie 1 — designed by Leo Chang, who also crafted the Kyrie 2 and Kyrie 3. By 2017, Irving began working with Nethongkome, who led the design process for his past three signature models, the Kyrie 4, Kyrie 5 and Kyrie 6.

